

4.3 Moral Responsibility Revision Notes

Key Questions:

- What is the relationship between personhood and moral responsibility?
- Is moral responsibility contingent upon certain capacities or characteristics of a person?
- How do different philosophical traditions approach the concept of moral responsibility in relation to personhood?

Philosophers:

1. Immanuel Kant (1724-1804)

- **Viewpoint: Autonomy and Moral Law**
- **Argument:** Kant argued that moral responsibility is intrinsically linked to autonomy and the capacity to act according to moral laws. He believed that true moral agents are those who can legislate moral laws for themselves through reason. For Kant, personhood is defined by the ability to act out of duty and to be held accountable for one's actions based on rational principles.
- **Counter-Argument:** Critics argue that Kant's strict criteria for moral responsibility may exclude individuals who lack full autonomy, such as children or those with cognitive impairments. This raises questions about the inclusivity of his moral framework and whether it adequately accounts for all persons.

2. John Stuart Mill (1806-1873)

- **Viewpoint: Utilitarianism and Consequentialism**
- **Argument:** Mill's utilitarianism emphasizes the consequences of actions in determining moral responsibility. He argued that individuals are morally responsible for their actions insofar as those actions contribute to overall happiness or well-being. For Mill, moral responsibility is tied to the ability to foresee the consequences of one's actions and to act in ways that promote the greater good.
- **Counter-Argument:** Critics of Mill's approach contend that it can lead to morally questionable decisions if individual rights are sacrificed for the sake of collective happiness. This raises concerns about whether moral responsibility can be adequately defined by utilitarian principles alone.

3. Harry Frankfurt (1929-Present)

- **Viewpoint: Hierarchical Model of Free Will**
- **Argument:** Frankfurt proposed a nuanced view of moral responsibility that distinguishes between first-order desires (basic desires) and second-order desires (desires about desires). He argued that individuals are morally responsible when they act according to their second-order desires, reflecting their true self. For Frankfurt, personhood involves the capacity to reflect on one's motivations and to align actions with one's authentic values.
- **Counter-Argument:** Critics may argue that Frankfurt's model complicates the notion of moral responsibility by introducing subjective elements that can vary widely among individuals. This raises questions about the consistency and universality of moral responsibility across different contexts.

4. Susan Wolf (1935-Present)

- **Viewpoint: Moral Responsibility and Sanity**
- **Argument:** Wolf argues that moral responsibility requires not only the capacity for rational decision-making but also a certain level of sanity or psychological health. She posits that individuals who lack the ability to understand or control their actions (e.g., due to mental illness) may not be fully morally responsible. For Wolf, personhood is tied to the capacity for rational reflection and the ability to engage with moral norms.
- **Counter-Argument:** Critics of Wolf's view may argue that it risks excluding individuals with mental health issues from moral consideration, raising ethical concerns about how society treats those who may not meet her criteria for moral responsibility.

Conclusion: The exploration of personhood and moral responsibility encompasses a variety of perspectives, including the autonomy-based framework of Kant, the consequentialist approach of Mill, the hierarchical model of Frankfurt, and the sanity requirement proposed by Wolf. Understanding these diverse viewpoints enriches our comprehension of the complexities surrounding moral responsibility and its relationship to personhood.